

PERSONAL LEARNING PROJECT · SEPTEMBER 2026

# A1 Lens

A listing-quality audit and competitor price lens for the public a1techdeals.com catalogue — built to learn the business before day one.

Product pages audited

**1,000**

every page in the public sitemap, 27 rules each

Products price-checked

**10**

against Currys and Argos, exact-variant matched

Findings with a stated fix

**6,012**

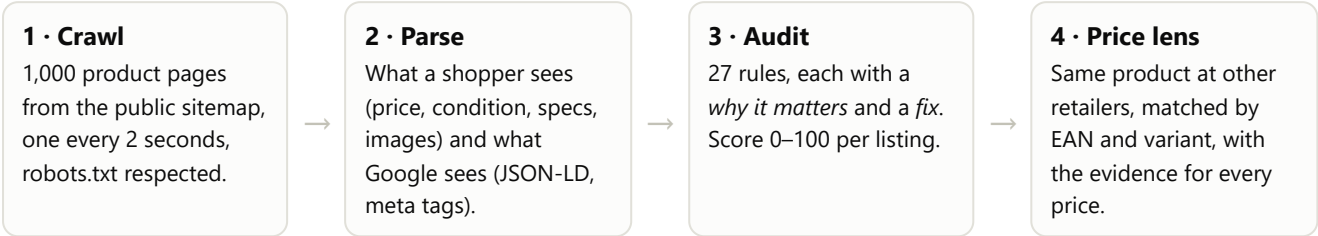
grouped into template, content and pricing work

Prepared by **Ahsanullah Daud**

Source and full write-up: [github.com/ahsanullahdaud/a1-lens](https://github.com/ahsanullahdaud/a1-lens)

# What it is, and what it found

I wanted to understand A1's catalogue and pricing model from the inside before I joined, so I built a tool that reads the public site the way Google and a shopper do, scores every listing, and compares prices with the high street. Everything below comes from that tool; nothing internal was used.



## Five things worth knowing

One import, not 565 problems

56%

of listings share a distributor-feed signature: brand/EAN-only specs, one image, a one-line description

Curated catalogue is healthy

82

average score for the other 404 listings (72 overall)

A1 is cheapest on

9 / 10

products checked against Currys and Argos; median 17% cheaper

One price is off-market

+£221

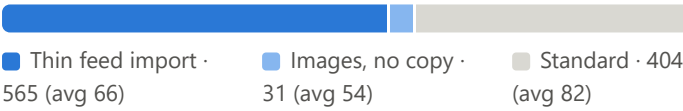
PS5 Pro 2TB at £1,009.99 vs £789 at both high-street chains

Grades that leapfrog

9

listings where a worse condition costs more than a better one

## How the catalogue splits

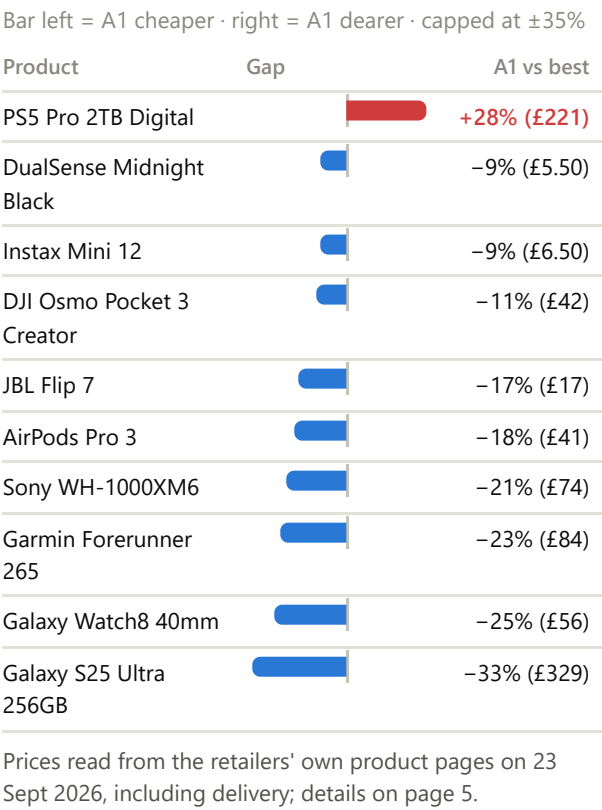


The import is almost entirely Computing, Office and Home Appliances stock (Ubiquiti, Mercodan, HP, Lenovo, CoreParts...). 99% of it carries an EAN, which is the key that makes bulk enrichment possible.

## Average score by category

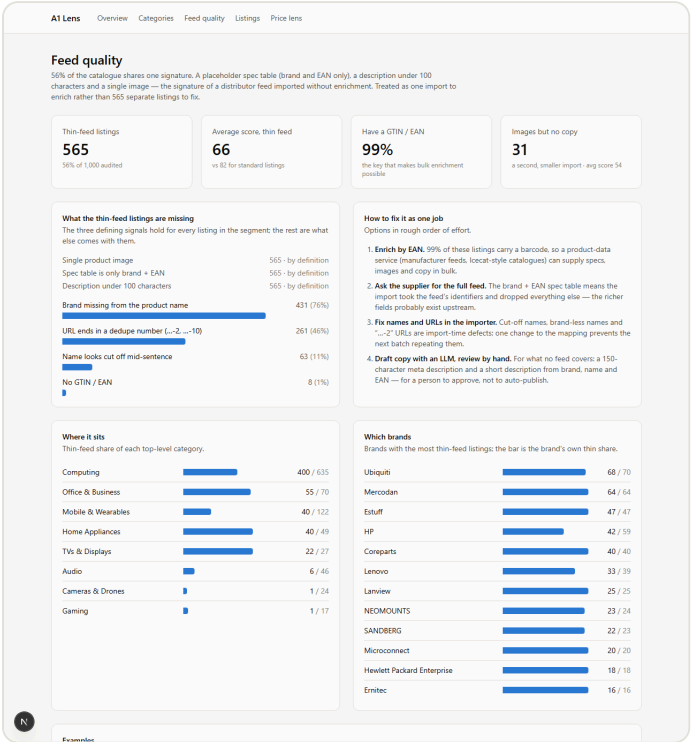
| Category           | Listings | Avg score | Thin-feed |
|--------------------|----------|-----------|-----------|
| Gaming             | 17       | 83        | 1         |
| Audio              | 46       | 83        | 6         |
| Cameras & Drones   | 24       | 82        | 1         |
| Mobile & Wearables | 122      | 78        | 40        |
| Computing          | 635      | 70        | 400       |
| Office & Business  | 70       | 69        | 55        |
| Home Appliances    | 49       | 69        | 40        |
| TVs & Displays     | 27       | 66        | 22        |

## A1 vs the cheapest comparable retailer



# Most of the catalogue is one un-enriched import

565 listings look nothing like the rest of the site. They share a signature: a spec table containing only *Brand* and *EAN*, a description under 100 characters and a single image. That is what a distributor feed looks like when only its identifiers are mapped — which means the fix is one import job, not 565 pieces of content work.



The Feed quality page in A1 Lens: size of the segment, what comes with it, where it sits, which brands.

## What comes with the signature

| Symptom                                              | Share of the 565 |
|------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| Brand missing from the product name                  | 76%              |
| URL ends in a dedupe counter (...-2, ...-38)         | 46%              |
| Name cut off mid-phrase ("Portable Spot Welder for") | 11%              |
| Has an EAN — the key to enrichment                   | 99%              |

## Where it sits

| Category           | Thin-feed / total |
|--------------------|-------------------|
| Computing          | 400 / 635         |
| Office & Business  | 55 / 70           |
| Home Appliances    | 40 / 49           |
| TVs & Displays     | 22 / 27           |
| Mobile & Wearables | 40 / 122          |

**Why it matters.** These pages can't rank, can't convert and generate "what's in the box?" questions. Because 99% carry an EAN, specs, images and copy can be pulled in bulk from a product-data service or the supplier's full feed, and the importer's name/URL mapping can be fixed once so the next batch doesn't repeat it.

## 27 rules, and where the fixes are cheap

A rule that hits nearly every listing is a template fix — one code change clears it everywhere. A rule that hits a handful is content or data work. The dashboard separates the two.

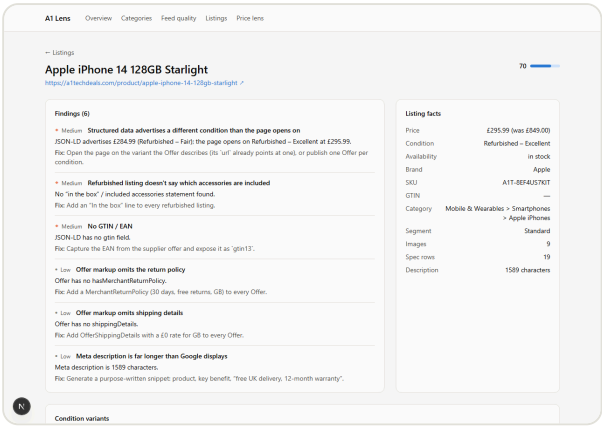
### Template fixes (one change each)

| Rule                                                             | Listings |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| Offer markup omits return policy / shipping details              | 968      |
| Meta description is the whole product description (1,000+ chars) | 378      |
| Title tag too long for search results                            | 323      |
| Out-of-stock page drops its Offer markup entirely                | 32       |
| JSON-LD advertises a cheaper variant than the page opens on      | 31       |

### Content and data work

| Rule                                        | Listings |
|---------------------------------------------|----------|
| Fewer than three product images             | 638      |
| Description under 300 characters            | 625      |
| Spec table has four rows or fewer           | 557      |
| Mains-powered product, plug type not stated | 111      |
| No GTIN / EAN                               | 72       |
| Name cut off or malformed                   | 64       |
| Refurbished, accessories not stated         | 17       |

The plug-type and accessories rules come straight from A1's own 1-star Trustpilot themes ("came with a European plug ... not clear in the description").



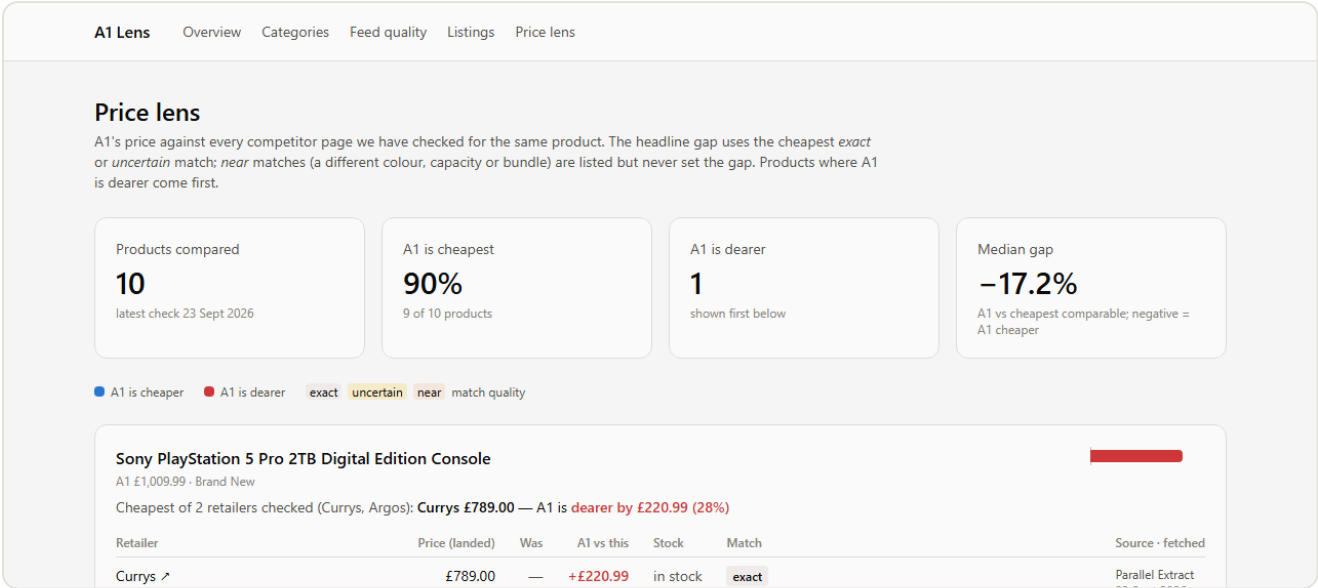
One listing in A1 Lens: every finding with its fix, the facts, and the condition variants with their prices.

### Pricing anomalies the rules surfaced

- **Grades that leapfrog (9):** Open Box above Brand New on five Samsung flagships (S25 Ultra 512GB: £779.99 vs £711.99); Refurbished above New on the Galaxy Tab A11 and DJI Osmo Pocket 3; "Good" above "Excellent" on the iPhone 14. A side-effect of pricing each grade by its own winning supplier bid.
- **Search price ≠ landing price (31):** the structured data carries the cheapest grade's price while the page opens on a dearer one — a Merchant Center mismatch waiting to happen.
- **Variant not stated:** the Galaxy Watch8 and Watch7 never say Bluetooth or LTE in the name or specs; only a "BT" buried in *Box contents*.

# A1 wins on price — with one exception

Ten mainstream, Brand-New products with an EAN, compared with Currys and Argos on 23 September. Prices are the retailer's own page price including delivery; each one is stored with the exact snippet it was read from, the match quality, the source and the date.



The Price lens: products where A1 is dearer sort first; every row names the retailers checked, shows the match badge with its note, and the source and fetch date. "both" = Currys and Argos at the same price.

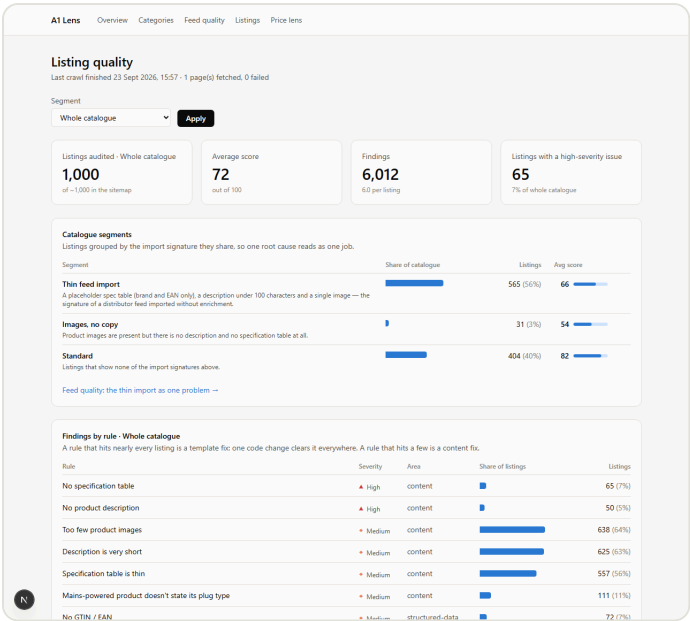
| Product                | A1        | Best comparable | Match                                  |
|------------------------|-----------|-----------------|----------------------------------------|
| PS5 Pro 2TB Digital    | £1,009.99 | £789.00 Currys  | <div>exact</div>                       |
| Galaxy S25 Ultra 256GB | £669.99   | £999.00 Argos   | <div>exact</div>                       |
| Galaxy Watch8 40mm     | £163.49   | £219.00 both    | <div>uncertain</div> <div>BT/LTE</div> |
| Forerunner 265 46mm    | £285.99   | £369.99 Argos   | <div>exact</div>                       |
| Sony WH-1000XM6        | £275.49   | £349.00 Currys  | <div>exact</div>                       |
| AirPods Pro 3          | £178.49   | £219.00 both    | <div>exact</div>                       |
| JBL Flip 7 White       | £81.99    | £129.00 both    | <div>near</div> <div>black only</div>  |
| Osmo Pocket 3 Combo    | £356.99   | £399.00 both    | <div>exact</div>                       |
| DualSense controller   | £54.49    | £59.99 both     | <div>exact</div>                       |
| Instax Mini 12         | £63.49    | £69.99 both     | <div>exact</div> <div>EAN =</div>      |

## How the comparison stays honest

- **Exact variant or it doesn't count.** Colour, capacity and bundle are checked against A1's listing; a near-match (Currys' black Flip 7) is shown but never sets the gap.
- **Main product's own price only.** Accessories, care plans, "£14/month" finance and delivery surcharges are set aside and listed as ignored on every row.
- **Evidence on every row.** The verbatim snippet the price came from, the retailer's was-price, delivery, stock, source and fetch date.
- **Polite by design.** Currys and Argos refuse crawlers, so their pages came through the Parallel Extract API rather than by working around the block.

**The exception.** The PS5 Pro 2TB sits at £1,009.99 against £789 at both chains and Sony's £699.99 list price — a plain console, not a bundle. Whichever supplier offer is winning that SKU is £220 off the market. The DualSense "was £79" also exceeds any retailer's was-price (list £64.99) and is worth a look under reference-pricing rules.

# Built to be extended, and to behave



The Overview: segments, findings by rule, score distribution — filterable by segment.

## Stack

Next.js 16 (App Router) · TypeScript · Postgres 17 with Drizzle ORM · cheerio · Vitest (59 tests on synthetic fixtures) · Parallel Extract API for retailers that block crawlers · eBay Browse API adapter ready for keys. Every rule carries a *why* and a *fix*; adding one is a single object and a test.

## Crawling etiquette

- Public pages only; robots.txt obeyed for every host, including Crawl-delay.
- One request every 2 seconds per host, honest User-Agent with a contact address.
- Stops at the first 401/403/429 — Currys and Argos both refused, and were left alone.
- Parsed fields stored, not page copies; test fixtures are synthetic.

## What I'd like to do with the team

| Effort | Proposal                                                                                                                                                                       |
|--------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Days   | <b>Enrich the thin import by EAN</b> — 558 listings with a barcode can pick up specs, images and copy in bulk; fix the importer's name/URL mapping so the next batch is clean. |
| Hours  | <b>Three template fixes</b> — return policy and shipping in the Offer markup, a purpose-written meta description, keep the Offer on out-of-stock pages.                        |
| Hours  | <b>Grade price guard</b> — never let Open Box or a refurbished grade price above Brand New; drive the JSON-LD from the variant the page opens on.                              |
| Hours  | <b>Nightly crawl</b> — price history and “A1 stopped being cheapest” alerts fall out of it.                                                                                    |
| Days   | <b>Widen the price lens</b> — eBay by EAN (new and refurbished), more retailers through the same pipeline, a “was-price honesty” check against RRP.                            |
| —      | <b>Or plug into what exists</b> — if the team already has a price-intelligence tool or a product feed, A1 Lens becomes the analysis layer on top of it.                        |

**A note on tone.** This was built from the outside, on public data, to learn — not to grade anyone's work. The most useful thing it says is that the biggest gaps are structural (one import, a few templates, one pricing rule), which is exactly the kind of thing a small engineering change can move.